

Fan Lifecycle & Organic Growth Strategy

CRM + Email + SEO for a Major Music Label

Prepared by **Jacob McLure**

UC Berkeley Economics '25 | jacobmclure@berkeley.edu

jacobmclure-collab.github.io/Jacob-McLure-Experiences

7

EMAIL SEQUENCE

4

LIFECYCLE STAGES

5

SEO PILLARS

6

AUDIENCE SEGMENTS

THE PROBLEM

Music labels spend heavily on acquisition during album release weeks, driving massive spikes in streams, followers, and email sign-ups. But once the release cycle ends, most of those new fans go dormant. Labels lack a structured CRM strategy that converts release-week excitement into long-term fan relationships. The result: high acquisition costs, low lifetime value, and a fanbase that only shows up when there's something new to sell them.

THE SOLUTION

A full-lifecycle CRM and SEO strategy that uses an artist album release as the acquisition hook, nurtures new fans through personalized email sequences, retains them between release cycles through editorial content and exclusive access, and recovers lapsed fans through targeted win-back campaigns. Layered with an organic SEO and web content strategy that drives discovery beyond paid media.

Not All Fans Are the Same.

Effective CRM starts with understanding that a fan who just discovered an artist through a TikTok sound is fundamentally different from a fan who's been to three tours. Treating them the same is how labels lose people. The following segments drive every email, content, and SEO decision in this strategy.

1. New Discoverers

First-time listeners who found the artist through a viral moment, playlist placement, or social media. They haven't committed yet. Goal: convert passive listeners into active fans through a welcome sequence that introduces the artist's world.

High volume, low loyalty. Needs nurture.

2. Casual Fans

Follow the artist on at least one platform. Stream new releases but don't engage between albums. Goal: deepen the relationship through exclusive content, early access, and personalized recommendations.

Medium volume, medium loyalty. Needs value.

3. Core Fans

Engaged consistently. Buy merch, attend shows, share content. They're already loyal. Goal: reward them, make them feel seen, and turn them into ambassadors who recruit new fans organically.

Lower volume, high loyalty. Needs recognition.

4. Lapsed Fans

Previously engaged but haven't opened an email or streamed in 90+ days. Goal: re-engage through a targeted win-back campaign before they fully disengage.

Variable volume. Needs a reason to come back.

5. Merch Buyers

Fans who have purchased merchandise or tickets. They've spent money, which signals a deeper level of commitment. Goal: cross-sell and upsell through product launches, tour announcements, and limited drops.

High-value segment. Needs exclusive offers.

6. Local Market Fans

Fans concentrated in specific cities where the artist is touring or has cultural relevance. Goal: drive ticket sales and event attendance through geo-targeted email and content.

Location-based. Needs localized messaging.

Four Stages. One Continuous Loop.

Most labels operate in a linear model: release, promote, move on. This strategy replaces that with a cyclical lifecycle where each stage feeds the next. Fans don't just enter the funnel during release week. They stay in it.

Stage 1: Acquisition

Triggered by an album/single release, viral moment, or paid media campaign. The goal is to capture email addresses and first-party data through landing pages, pre-save campaigns, and exclusive content offers. Every acquisition touchpoint should feel like an invitation into the artist's world, not a transaction.

Tactics: Pre-save landing pages with email capture, social media lead gen ads, contest/giveaway sign-ups, QR codes at live events, website pop-ups during release week.

Stage 2: Nurture

The 30 days after acquisition are the most important. This is where casual listeners become real fans. The welcome email sequence (detailed on the next pages) introduces the artist's story, discography, and community. The content is personal, editorial, and never purely promotional.

Tactics: 7-email welcome sequence, personalized content recommendations based on entry point, early access to unreleased content, behind-the-scenes exclusives.

Stage 3: Retention

Between release cycles, most labels go quiet. That's when fans disengage. This stage fills the gap with consistent value: editorial content, curated playlists, fan community features, and drip campaigns that keep the artist relevant in the fan's inbox without feeling like spam.

Tactics: Monthly editorial newsletter, playlist updates, fan spotlight features, anniversary/throwback content, birthday emails, listening milestone celebrations.

Stage 4: Win-Back

Fans who haven't engaged in 90+ days get a targeted re-engagement campaign. The tone shifts from 'here's what's new' to 'we miss you.' If they don't respond after three attempts, they're suppressed from the active list to protect deliverability.

Tactics: 3-email win-back sequence, subject lines that acknowledge the gap, exclusive offer or content as incentive, final 'last chance' email before suppression.

The First 30 Days.

This 7-email sequence is triggered when a new fan enters the CRM through any acquisition channel. The goal is to move them from 'I just heard this song' to 'I'm a fan of this artist.' Each email is designed to feel personal, not promotional. Subject lines are written to be opened, not just sent.

Subject: You just found your new favorite artist.

EMAIL 1

Send: Immediately after sign-up | Segment: New Discoverers

Purpose: First impression. Set the tone.

Short, warm, personal. Introduces who the artist is in 2-3 sentences. Links to their most essential playlist or album. Feels like a friend recommending music, not a brand onboarding a customer. Includes a personal note or quote from the artist.

CTA: Listen to [Artist]'s Essential Playlist

Subject: Why [Latest Album] almost didn't happen.

EMAIL 2

Send: Day 3 | Segment: New Discoverers

Purpose: Deepen the connection through storytelling.

Editorial-style email that tells the story behind the most recent release. What inspired it, what it means to the artist, what fans should listen for. This is content marketing, not a sales pitch. Includes embedded audio or video if possible.

CTA: Read the Full Story

Subject: Based on what you've been listening to...

EMAIL 3

Send: Day 7 | Segment: New Discoverers

Purpose: Personalized recommendations based on entry point.

If the fan entered through a specific song or album, this email recommends similar tracks from the artist's catalog and from related artists on the label. Uses listening behavior data to personalize. Shows the fan that the label understands their taste.

CTA: Explore Your Recommendations

Subject: Nobody else has heard this yet.

EMAIL 4

Send: Day 10 | Segment: New Discoverers + Casual Fans

Purpose: Exclusive content that rewards engagement.

Behind-the-scenes video, acoustic session, studio footage, or unreleased demo. This email is only sent to fans who opened at least one of the first three emails. It rewards engagement and builds a sense of exclusivity. Subject line creates curiosity.

CTA: Watch the Exclusive Session

Subject: [Artist] is playing 20 minutes from you.

EMAIL 5

Send: Day 14 | Segment: Local Market Fans + Casual Fans

Purpose: Convert engagement into ticket sales.

Geo-targeted email announcing upcoming tour dates in the fan's city. If no tour dates exist for their market, this email instead promotes a livestream event or virtual experience. Includes early access or presale code for email subscribers only.

CTA: Get Presale Access

Subject: First 500 only. The [Album] collection.

EMAIL 6

Send: Day 21 | Segment: Casual Fans + Core Fans + Merch Buyers

Purpose: Drive merch revenue from engaged fans.

New merchandise drop tied to the album release. Limited-edition items create urgency. Email only goes to fans who have engaged at least twice in the sequence. Not sent to unengaged contacts. Clean, visual layout with product imagery.

CTA: Shop the Drop

Subject: You're one of us now. Here's what's next.

EMAIL 7

Send: Day 30 | Segment: All Engaged Subscribers

Purpose: Transition from welcome sequence to ongoing relationship.

Closes the onboarding arc. Tells the fan what to expect going forward: monthly newsletters, early access to releases, tour announcements. Invites them to follow on social, join the fan community, or refer a friend. Sets expectations so future emails don't feel unexpected.

CTA: Join the Community

Bringing Lapsed Fans Home.

Triggered when a subscriber hasn't opened an email or streamed in 90+ days. Three emails over three weeks. If no engagement after the third email, the contact is suppressed from the active list to protect sender reputation and deliverability rates.

Subject: So... a lot happened while you were gone.

EMAIL W1

Send: Day 1 of win-back trigger | Segment: Lapsed Fans (90+ days inactive)

Purpose: Acknowledge the gap. No pressure.

Simple, honest subject line. Body is short: 'We noticed you've been quiet. No pressure, but here's what you've missed.' Includes a curated list of the 3 most important things that happened since they last engaged: a new release, a tour announcement, a viral moment. Tone is warm, not desperate.

CTA: See What You Missed

Subject: We saved something for you.

EMAIL W2

Send: Day 8 | Segment: Lapsed Fans (still inactive after W1)

Purpose: Exclusive offer as incentive to re-engage.

Offers something the fan can't get anywhere else: early access to an unreleased track, a discount code for merch, or a free digital download. The exclusivity signals that the label values this fan specifically. Subject line is personal and curiosity-driven.

CTA: Claim Your Exclusive

Subject: No hard feelings. But this is the last one.

EMAIL W3

Send: Day 21 | Segment: Lapsed Fans (still inactive after W2)

Purpose: Final attempt before suppression.

Transparent email that says: 'If we don't hear from you, we'll stop emailing so we're not cluttering your inbox.' Gives the fan a one-click option to stay subscribed. This protects deliverability while giving the fan agency. Fans who click stay on the list. Everyone else gets suppressed.

CTA: Keep Me Subscribed / Unsubscribe

Organic Discovery Beyond Paid Media.

Email gets fans who already know the artist. SEO gets fans who don't know them yet. A label's website and artist pages should rank for the searches that potential fans are already making. This strategy identifies five content pillars that drive organic traffic, build authority, and convert searchers into email subscribers.

1. Artist Story Pages

Long-form editorial pages for each artist that go beyond a bio. These pages tell the artist's story in a way that ranks for branded search queries (e.g., '[Artist name] story,' '[Artist name] background'). Optimized with structured data, internal linking, and multimedia embeds. Each page includes an email capture form.

Target keywords: [Artist] biography, [Artist] story, [Artist] background, [Artist] interview

2. Album/Release Landing Pages

Dedicated SEO-optimized landing pages for every major release. These pages serve as the hub for all release-related content: streaming links, tracklists, credits, behind-the-scenes content, and tour dates. They rank for release-related searches and capture email addresses through pre-save and exclusive content offers.

Target keywords: [Artist] new album, [Album name] tracklist, [Album name] release date, [Artist] tour dates

3. Editorial Blog Content

A regularly updated blog publishing 2-4 articles per month: artist features, playlist roundups, genre deep-dives, and cultural commentary. This content targets informational search queries that attract new audiences who aren't searching for a specific artist yet but are searching for the music and culture around them.

Target keywords: best new [genre] albums, [genre] playlist 2026, artists like [Artist], new music Friday picks

4. Lyrics and Song Meaning Pages

Lyrics pages are some of the highest-traffic music content on the internet, dominated by Genius and AZLyrics. A label can reclaim some of that traffic by publishing official lyrics with artist-provided context and meaning. These pages rank for '[Song] lyrics' and '[Song] meaning' queries.

Target keywords: [Song] lyrics, [Song] meaning, [Song] explained, [Artist] lyrics

5. Local/Tour SEO

City-specific landing pages for tour dates that rank for '[Artist] [City] concert' and '[Artist] tickets [City]' queries. These pages include venue information, setlist history, local fan community links, and email capture for tour updates. Geo-targeted content that drives ticket sales through organic search.

Target keywords: [Artist] [City] concert 2026, [Artist] tour dates, [Artist] tickets [City], [Artist] setlist

The Infrastructure.

- Site Speed: Artist pages and release landing pages must load in under 2 seconds on mobile. Compress images, lazy-load media embeds, and minimize JavaScript. Google's Core Web Vitals directly impact search rankings.
- Schema Markup: Implement MusicGroup, MusicAlbum, MusicEvent, and Article structured data across all relevant pages. This enables rich results in Google search (event cards, album artwork, track listings) and increases click-through rates.
- Internal Linking: Every artist page should link to their releases, tour dates, and related artists on the label. Every blog post should link to relevant artist pages. This distributes page authority and helps Google crawl the full site efficiently.
- Mobile-First Design: Over 70% of music discovery happens on mobile. All landing pages, email capture forms, and content must be designed mobile-first. Email templates must render correctly across all major email clients (Gmail, Apple Mail, Outlook).
- Email Capture on Every Page: No page on the site should exist without an email capture opportunity. Pop-ups on first visit (with 5-second delay), inline forms within editorial content, and sticky footer bars on artist pages. Every organic visitor is a potential CRM contact.
- UTM Tracking: Every link in every email must be tagged with UTM parameters (source, medium, campaign, content) to track which emails drive streams, ticket sales, and merch revenue. This data closes the loop between CRM activity and business outcomes.
- A/B Testing Framework: Subject lines, send times, CTA button copy, and email layout should be A/B tested on every send with a minimum 10% holdout group. Winning variants inform future sends. Document results in a shared testing log.

KPIS & MEASUREMENT

How We Know It's Working.

Email Open Rate

Target: 35%+ for welcome sequence, 25%+ for ongoing
Industry avg: 21%. Welcome emails historically outperform.

Click-Through Rate

Target: 5%+ for welcome, 3%+ for ongoing
Measured as unique clicks / delivered emails.

List Growth Rate

Target: 10% month-over-month during release periods
Net new subscribers minus unsubscribes and bounces.

Win-Back Recovery Rate

Target: 15%+ of lapsed fans re-engaged
Fans who open or click within the 3-email win-back sequence.

Organic Search Traffic

Target: 20% increase in 6 months to artist/release pages

Measured via GA4. Excludes branded search for pure organic growth.

Email-to-Stream Conversion

Target: 8%+ of email clicks result in a stream

Requires UTM tracking and streaming platform integration.

Email-to-Purchase Conversion

Target: 3%+ of merch email clicks result in purchase

Tracked through e-commerce UTM attribution.

Deliverability Rate

Target: 98%+ inbox placement

Maintained through list hygiene, win-back suppression, and authentication.

Why This Strategy Works.

The music industry spends billions on acquisition and almost nothing on retention. Labels treat every release cycle as a fresh start, rebuilding audiences from scratch instead of nurturing the fans they already have. This strategy exists to fix that.

- The lifecycle framework turns a one-time album release into an ongoing relationship. Fans acquired during release week become long-term CRM contacts who generate value across multiple release cycles.
- The 7-email welcome sequence is designed to feel editorial, not promotional. Each email earns the right to send the next one by delivering genuine value: storytelling, exclusives, recommendations, and community.
- The win-back sequence protects the most overlooked metric in email marketing: deliverability. Suppressing unengaged contacts isn't losing fans. It's protecting the ability to reach the fans who actually care.
- The SEO strategy creates a discovery engine that works 24/7 without ad spend. Every artist page, release landing page, and blog post is a potential entry point for a fan who doesn't know the artist yet but is searching for the music around them.
- The audience segmentation ensures that a core fan who's been to three tours never receives the same email as someone who heard one song on TikTok yesterday. Personalization isn't a feature. It's the entire strategy.
- Every recommendation is measurable. UTM tracking, A/B testing, and defined KPIs ensure that the strategy isn't just theoretically sound but operationally accountable. If something isn't working, the data will show it, and the strategy adapts.

This project was created by Jacob McLure as a practice exercise in CRM strategy, email marketing, and SEO.

It is not affiliated with or endorsed by any specific label or artist.

jacobmclure@berkeley.edu | (310) 614-3893
jacobmclure-collab.github.io/Jacob-McLure-Experiences